Deciding with AI

A field guide for getting your digital assistant to actually assist: to think, to choose, and to get unstuck.

Scan me. Every prompt in this guide, with copy buttons.

> **You supply the values. The AI supplies options, tradeoffs, and objections. You own the decision.**

Ask an AI "which is best?" and you get a confident answer with no criteria: best for whom, at what cost? That is the whole decision, and the AI just made it for you by guessing. A good prompt hands over the facts and keeps the values.

	Weak prompt	Strong prompt
You type	Should I use inheritance or composition?	I'm a Python beginner on a 3-person team with one week. Compare inheritance and composition on build time, ease of understanding, and adding room types later. Don't recommend one. Flag one claim I should verify.
You get	A verdict that sounds sure	A comparison you can argue with
Who decided	The AI, by accident	You, on purpose

Rules of thumb

When you forget everything else, remember these.

1. **Cheap and reversible? Decide fast.** Save the checking for choices that cost a lot to get wrong.
2. **Commit before you ask.** Write your guess first, or the AI's first answer becomes yours.
3. **Trust scales with how easy a mistake is to catch.** Brainstorming names: loose. A dose or a deadline: never on its word alone.
4. **Specific is checkable, and specific is where inventions hide.** Check names, numbers, quotes, links, and function names first.
5. **Disagreement is information. Agreement is a clue,** not proof.
6. **The first answer is a draft.** The second round is where it gets good.
7. **If it flatters you, get suspicious.** If it caves without new evidence, discount what it said.
8. **Longer is not better.** Ask for the simplest version that works.
9. **Check the one thing that would hurt most if it were wrong.** You can't check everything, so choose.
10. **Vague in, vague out.** Goal, context, limits, format.
11. **A chat that's going in circles won't fix itself.** Restart with a summary.
12. **Private stays private.** When unsure, leave it out.
13. **If your name is on it, you answer for it.**

What assistants do well, and where they trip

Great at	Watch out for
Gathering and summarizing a lot, fast	Invented facts, sources, and numbers; outdated information
Brainstorming options you hadn't thought of	Options it can't know about, because it doesn't know your situation
Explaining an idea at your level	Smooth, convincing explanations of things that are wrong
Comparing options and spotting risks	Quietly choosing your values for you
Breaking a big, scary job into small steps	Plans so long that they become another thing to avoid
Patient, tireless, awake at 2 a.m.	It doesn't know when it doesn't know

The routine: seven moves

Run them in order for any choice that matters. A small choice needs only moves 1 and 7. The more a mistake costs, the more of the seven you run. Fill in the `[brackets]`.

1 **Size it**

How much does a wrong choice cost, and can you undo it? Cheap and reversible: decide now and skip to move 7. Costly or permanent: run every move.

2 **Commit first, then brief the AI**

On paper, before you open any AI: your top three priorities and your gut guess. Then start the chat with a briefing.

THE BRIEFING

```
I need to decide: [the decision, in one sentence].
What I care about, in order: [1], [2], [3].
Limits: [deadline, budget, skills, rules].
My guess: [guess]. I might be wrong.
Don't recommend anything yet. Ask me up to five questions that would change your analysis, one at a time.
```

3 **Widen**

WIDEN

```
What options haven't I considered, including doing nothing and a cheaper version of each? Is this secretly two decisions?
```

4 **Compare on your criteria**

COMPARE

```
Compare [A], [B], and [C] on [my criteria]. Rate each 1 to 3 with a one-sentence reason. List your assumptions and one claim I should verify. Don't recommend one, and don't decide which criterion matters most.
```

5 **Attack your favorite**

ARGUE AGAINST ME

```
I'm leaning toward [choice] because [reason]. Make the strongest case against it. What evidence would change your mind?
```

PREMORTEM

```
It's [three months] from now and this decision failed. Give three likely reasons, and an early warning sign for each.
```

6 **Cross-check**

Take the claims that matter to a second AI (page 3), then to something outside every chat: a source, a test you run, or a person.

7 **Decide and log**

Write three lines: **I chose ___. I gave up ___. I'd change my mind if ___.** A decision you can't explain next month was a coin flip.

Two prompts for any chat

ASSISTANT MODE (PASTE FIRST)

```
Act as my decision assistant. Keep me honest; don't just make me feel good. Ask one question at a time. Point out anything I'm assuming without evidence. When I state a preference, tell me what it costs me. Never choose for me.
```

CLEAN RESTART (WHEN A CHAT WANDERS OR REPEATS A MISTAKE)

```
Summarize this conversation in ten lines: the goal, my criteria, the options, what we verified, and what's still open. I'll paste it into a fresh chat.
```

A role like "decision assistant" sets the tone. It doesn't make the answers more true, so you still check them.

Catch the AI in a lie

An AI doesn't lie on purpose. It predicts fluent text, and sometimes fluent text is invented: a study that doesn't exist, a function nobody wrote. Think of a brilliant improv actor who never says "I don't know." Confidence tells you nothing, so get a second opinion: open a fresh chat, ideally in a **different** AI, and paste the first answer under one of these.

1 · DID IT LIE?

```
Which statements in this answer are false, outdated, or unsupported? For each, what's true and how could I confirm it? If you're unsure, say so.
```

2 · DID IT MAKE ANYTHING UP?

```
Which names, sources, quotes, numbers, links, or technical terms here might not exist? How do I look each one up?
```

3 · DID IT LEAVE ANYTHING OUT?

```
What options, risks, or viewpoints are missing? Who is affected but never mentioned?
```

4 · DID IT GO OVERBOARD?

```
Where is this overconfident, too long, or too complicated? What's the simplest version that still works?
```

5 · WHAT WOULD MAKE IT BETTER?

```
I'm [one line about me and my goal]. What three changes would make this more useful to me? Write the follow-up question I should send the first AI.
```

6 · WHAT WOULD CHANGE ITS MIND?

```
What evidence would change this conclusion? What's the strongest argument against it?
```

ALL SIX AT ONCE (SHORT ON TIME)

```
Review the answer below like a skeptical colleague. In a short section each: (1) anything false? (2) made up? (3) left out? (4) overboard? (5) what would make it better? (6) what would change your mind? Be blunt.
[paste the answer]
```

Then don't stop there. The second AI can be wrong too. Treat its flags as a to-do list, not a verdict. Check each one, and take the real ones back to the first AI: "Another assistant says X is wrong. Show your evidence."

How much to trust it: the evidence ladder

Climb as high as the stakes demand.

1 One AI says it · **2** Two AIs agree · **3** A source you opened says it · **4** You ran or tested it · **5** A qualified person confirms it

Worked example

AI #1 says: "*To get the date three days from now, use* `datetime.today().add_days(3)`." AI #2 flags it: Python's `datetime` has no `add_days`; the usual way is `+ timedelta(days=3)`. Settle it by running both, not by voting. One works and one raises `AttributeError`. That is rung 4, and it took thirty seconds.

You already know how to do this

In real life	What you already know	With an AI
GPS	Usually right, until it routes you down a closed road. You're still the driver.	Follow it on easy turns. Look up when the stakes are high.
Asking a stranger for directions	People answer confidently even when guessing.	Ask a second person: a second AI.
The friend who loves every idea	"Great plan!" feels good and tells you nothing.	Ask for the case against. Push back and see if it folds.
The group-project teammate	"Yeah, I did my part." Then you open the file.	Run it yourself. "All tests pass" is a claim.
Gossip	Five people repeating a rumor is still one rumor.	Two AIs agreeing is a clue. Find the original source.
Saving before the boss fight	You don't try the hard level without a save point.	Commit with git before each AI change.

Get unstuck: the garage shelf

Some decisions aren't hard. They're *heavy*. It's the shelf in the garage you've stared at for six weeks, the email you keep not sending, the project you can't start. It isn't complicated; it's living rent-free in your head. An assistant is great at shrinking it down to something you can do before lunch.

EMPTY YOUR HEAD

```
I'm going to dump everything about [the thing]
that's bugging me, messy and in no order. Sort
it into: do now, decide later, and let go. Then
tell me the one thing that matters most.
```

SHRINK IT

```
I've been avoiding [task]. What's the smallest
first step that takes under 15 minutes and needs
no decisions? Then the next one.
```

DEFINE "GOOD ENOUGH"

```
What does "done enough" look like for [task]?
Give me a checklist of no more than five items,
so I know when to stop.
```

KEEP ME COMPANY

```
I'm doing [task] right now. Give me one step at
a time. When I type "done," give me the next
step and nothing else.
```

This is a tool for getting moving, not a substitute for people. If the worry is about more than a task, or it won't let go, talk to someone: a friend, an advisor, or campus counseling.

Rules for building things with AI

They hold for code, lab reports, and business plans alike. The loop: define, plan, slice, build, test, review, save.

1. **Define "done" first.** Three example inputs and the outputs you expect, or a checklist.
2. **Plan, then build.** "Make a plan and show me before changing anything."
3. **Slice small.** One piece at a time: build it, test it, move on.
4. **Never ship what you can't explain.** If you can't change it without the AI, you don't own it yet.
5. **Run it yourself.** Try odd inputs: empty, huge, unexpected.
6. **Check every name it gives you.** Invented libraries and functions are a real hazard.
7. **Keep save points.** Commit with git before each AI change.
8. **Say how you used it.** Which tool, for what, and how you checked.

When AI should not decide

Situation	Use AI for	Then
Medical, legal, financial, or safety	Preparing better questions; explaining terms	Take the questions to a qualified person.
Private data (yours or anyone's)	Nothing, or a fully anonymized version	When unsure, leave it out.
Graded work	Only what your syllabus allows	Say what you used it for and how you checked.
Decisions about people	Organizing criteria; spotting gaps	A human decides and answers for it.

Your turn: try it in the playground

Pick one, open two AI tools (or two fresh chats), and run the seven moves.

1. **The class problem.** Three beginners have one week to build a room-reservation program. Inheritance, composition in one file, or composition across modules? Hint: ask whether those are really three options.
2. **A real choice of yours.** A class schedule, a laptop, a project idea. Leave out anything private.
3. **Your garage shelf.** The thing you've been putting off. Run the four unstuck prompts and do the first step today.

Before you act on any answer, ask: What would I check? Who's left out? What would make me stop?